SUNFLOWER SEED "RISOTTO"
WITH MAPLE-ROASTED SQUASH AND PRAIRIE PESTO

serves 4

In *Buffalo Bird Woman's Garden*, the Hidatsa gardener (see The Pantry Recipes, page 24) describes making a dish out of sunflower seeds that gets cooked slowly with vegetables. "Meat was not boiled with the mess, as the sunflower seed gave sufficient oil to furnish fat," she says. Here, I reimagine this Hidatsa family meal as a sort of risotto topped with roasted and glazed squash.

Cook the squash: Preheat the oven to 425°F.

Spread the squash wedges on a baking sheet and brush both sides with the oil. Season all over with salt.

Roast the squash for about 30 minutes, or until browned on the bottom and tender. Brush both sides with the maple syrup and continue roasting for another 5 minutes to glaze.

Make the risotto: Drain and rinse the seeds. Measure out ¾ cup of the soaked seeds and transfer to a blender with ¾ cup water. Puree to form a smooth sunflower cream. Set the remaining whole sunflower seeds aside separately.

In a saucepan, heat the oil over medium heat. Add the onion, season with salt, and cook, stirring, for about 5 minutes, or until translucent. Add the garlic and cook, stirring, for about 2 minutes, until fragrant and softened. Add the apple cider and vinegar and bring to a boil, then cook until the liquid reduces to about 1 tablespoon.

Add the reserved soaked sunflower seeds (that aren't pureed) and the stock and bring to a simmer over medium heat. Cover and reduce the heat to medium-low if needed to prevent the liquid from boiling over. Cook for about 25 minutes, or until the seeds are tender but not quite soft.

Uncover and stir in the sunflower cream. Cook until the "risotto" is heated through and the sunflower seeds look like they're suspended in a creamy sauce. (If it seems very loose, increase the heat to medium and simmer, allowing some of the excess liquid to evaporate.)

Taste and season with salt, as needed. Serve topped with wedges of glazed squash and drizzle with the pesto.

SQUASH

- 1 (1-pound) piece Hidatsa winter squash or kabocha squash, seeded and cut into 1-inch-thick wedges
- 2 tablespoons sunflower oil
- Sea salt
- 1 tablespoon maple syrup

RISOTTO

- 2 cups sunflower seeds, soaked for 8 hours
- 2 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- Sea salt
- 4 garlic cloves, finely chopped
- ¼ cup fresh apple cider
- 1 tablespoon cider vinegar
- 3 cups Roasted Bird Stock (page 40) or vegetable broth
- ½ cup Prairie Pesto (page 68), for serving

PRAIRIE PESTO

makes about 1 cup

This makes a thick, garlicky pesto using Indigenous ingredients. The flavor will vary widely depending on the greens you use, but the seeds give it richness and the sumac a nice bright note. To thin it out, add more oil if you like.

- 2 garlic cloves, peeled but whole
- ½ cup toasted sunflower seeds or pepitas, or a mix of the two
- 2 cups mixed wild greens, such as lamb's quarters, amaranth greens, common plantain, young chicory greens, dandelion, and onion greens
- 1 teaspoon ground sumac
- ½ cup sunflower oil
- Sea salt
- 1 teaspoon cider vinegar

In a blender or mini food processor, pulse the garlic cloves and toasted seeds until coarsely chopped. Add the greens and sumac, then pulse to chop again. With the machine running, add the oil, then pulse in a pinch of salt.

Add the vinegar and pulse just once or twice to combine. Taste and season with more salt, as needed.

The pesto can be refrigerated in an airtight container for up to 5 days.